

1:90

THE FREE GUIDE

THE 90-DAY PLANNING GUIDE

How to turn one strategic priority into aligned action
across your whole team — the Arc → Wave → Milestone →
Task method, step by step.

START HERE

WHY STRATEGY FAILS AT EXECUTION

Ask most business owners whether their team knows the company's top three priorities for the next 90 days, and the honest answer is: **"I think so."**

That uncertainty is expensive. It's the gap between the strategy you set in the boardroom and the work that actually happens on Monday morning. Most businesses don't fail because they pick the wrong strategy. They fail because the strategy never reaches the people doing the work.

You've probably felt the symptoms:

- The annual plan that felt exciting in January and was forgotten by March.
- A team that's **busy** — but not moving the needle on the things that matter.
- Priorities that shift every week, so nothing ever finishes.
- Task tools full of activity that no-one can connect back to the actual goal.

THE CORE PROBLEM

Annual plans are too long to stay urgent. Weekly sprints are too short to be strategic. There's nothing connecting the two — no **operating system** that turns a 12-month vision into this quarter's focused action.

That's the gap 1:90 Align was built to close. This guide gives you the complete method — the same framework we use with UK businesses — so you can start running it yourself, this quarter.

WHAT YOU'LL HAVE BY THE END OF THIS GUIDE

- One clear 90-day priority your whole team can rally behind
- A simple structure that connects that priority to daily work
- A repeatable rhythm so plans don't drift after kick-off

THE METHOD

ONE VISION. NINETY DAYS.

The name says it: **1:90** means **one** strategic priority, executed over **90** days. Focus is the whole point.

The method works as a four-level hierarchy. Every level connects to the one above it, so strategy at the top flows all the way down to the task someone picks up today.

ARC	Your one 90-day priority.	The single most important thing your business must achieve this quarter.
WAVE	Three 30-day sprints.	The Arc is delivered in three Waves, each with its own focus and a checkpoint at the end.
MILESTONE	The proof points.	Specific, owned, dated outcomes within each Wave that show you're on track.
TASK	The daily work.	The individual actions that deliver each Milestone — visible, assigned, and connected to the Arc.

WHY IT WORKS

90 days is **short enough to stay urgent** — you can see the finish line — but **long enough to matter**. Three 30-day Waves give you built-in checkpoints, so drift gets caught early instead of at year-end.

THE GOLDEN RULE: ONE ARC

The discipline that makes this work is the constraint. **One Arc per 90 days**. Not five priorities. Not "these are all important." One. The moment a business commits to a single strategic priority, focus compounds — and the team finally pulls in the same direction.

STEP 1

SET YOUR ARC

Your Arc is the one outcome that, if you achieved it in the next 90 days, would move your business forward more than anything else.

HOW TO CHOOSE IT

Ask: "**What's the single biggest constraint on our growth right now?**" Your Arc should attack that constraint. It might be:

- Launch the new service line and land the first 10 customers
- Fix the delivery process so we stop missing deadlines
- Build the sales pipeline to £X in qualified opportunities
- Get the team operating without the founder in every decision

A STRONG ARC IS:

- ▶ **Singular** — one priority, not a list
- ▶ **Specific** — you'll know clearly if you hit it
- ▶ **Ambitious but achievable** in 90 days
- ▶ **Owned** — one person is accountable for it (often the founder, at first)

WATCH OUT

If you can't choose between two Arcs, you haven't been honest about priorities yet. Pick the one that **unlocks** the other. Strategy is sacrifice — choosing what **not** to do this quarter is the point.

YOUR ARC

Our one priority for the next 90 days is:

We'll know we've achieved it when:

The person accountable is:

STEP 2

BREAK IT INTO THREE WAVES

A 90-day goal is still too big to act on directly. Split it into three 30-day Waves — each one a focused phase that builds on the last.

Most Arcs follow a natural arc of their own across the three Waves:

WAVE	TYPICAL FOCUS
Wave 1 Days 1–30	Foundation. Set up, remove blockers, get the right people and inputs in place. Build momentum with early, visible progress.
Wave 2 Days 31–60	Execution. The heavy lifting. This is where the core work of the Arc gets done. Protect this Wave from distraction.
Wave 3 Days 61–90	Consolidation. Finish, refine, and lock in the result. Prove the outcome and prepare to carry momentum into the next Arc.

THE CHECKPOINT

At the end of each Wave, hold a **30-minute Wave Review**: What did we complete? What's at risk? What does the next Wave need? This is the mechanism that stops plans drifting silently.

 **YOUR THREE WAVES**

Wave 1 (Foundation) focus:

Wave 2 (Execution) focus:

Wave 3 (Consolidation) focus:

STEPS 3 & 4

MILESTONES & TASKS

Waves give you phases. Milestones and Tasks make them real.

STEP 3 — DEFINE YOUR MILESTONES

Within each Wave, set **2–4 Milestones**: specific, dated, owned outcomes that prove the Wave is on track. A Milestone is not an activity ("work on the website") — it's a result ("new pricing page live and tested").

WEAK MILESTONE	STRONG MILESTONE
Improve onboarding	New 3-step onboarding live, first 5 clients through it by Day 25
Work on sales	10 qualified discovery calls booked by end of Wave 1

STEP 4 — ASSIGN THE TASKS

Each Milestone breaks into Tasks — the actual daily work, each with an owner. Because every Task ladders up to a Milestone, a Wave, and the Arc, **everyone can see how today's work connects to the quarter's priority**. That line of sight is what most task tools never give you.

THE RIPPLE — YOUR DAILY HEARTBEAT

Run a **15-minute daily stand-up** (we call it the Ripple). Each person answers three questions:

- What did I move forward yesterday?
- What am I moving forward today?
- What's blocking me?

Keep it standing, keep it short, keep it focused on the Arc.

MAKE IT STICK

THE REVIEW RHYTHM

A plan without a rhythm is just a document. The cadence is what keeps the system alive.

RHYTHM	WHEN	PURPOSE
Ripple	Daily, 15 min	Alignment & unblocking
Wave Review	Every 30 days	Check progress, reset the next Wave
Arc Reset	Every 90 days	Retrospective, then set the next Arc

That's the whole system. Set **one Arc**. Split it into **three Waves**. Prove each Wave with **Milestones**. Deliver them through **Tasks**, kept on track by the daily **Ripple**. Every 90 days, reset and go again.

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Don't try to roll this out across the whole company at once. **Run one Arc, with one team, for one quarter**. Prove it works. Then expand. Momentum beats perfection.

WANT HELP RUNNING YOUR FIRST ARC?

We work with UK business owners to install the 1:90 Align operating system — so your strategy actually reaches the frontline. Start with a focused Alignment Diagnostic, or just book a free call.

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Built in the UK, for UK businesses, by an operator who's run one.
Not another US framework. Not another task list.